

APPLE PEPPER SALSA

Crisp green apple & sweet pepper with a slow-building reaper-water heat

YIELD ~3 cups | PREP 0:20 | COOK 0:10 | CHILL 0:30 | TOTAL 1:00

HEAT — slow-building, back-palate lingering heat from a reaper-water infusion

INGREDIENTS

1	Granny Smith apple, finely diced	1000 mg	salt (about 1/6 tsp)
1 med	red onion, finely diced	1	lime, juiced
1	red bell pepper, finely diced	1 tbsp	apple cider vinegar
2 tbsp	fresh dill, chopped	½	dehydrated Carolina Reaper
2 tbsp	mayonnaise	3 tbsp	reaper water (reserved, see step 1)

METHOD

- 1 Boil the reaper. Add the ½ dehydrated Carolina Reaper to about ½ cup water, bring to a boil, and simmer 10 minutes. Turn on your vent — reaper steam is potent. Reserve the liquid and measure out 3 tbsp of reaper water; discard the pod (or see Chef's Notes).
- 2 Dress the apple first. Finely dice the Granny Smith apple and toss it right away with the lime juice and apple cider vinegar. The acid keeps it from browning while you prep the rest.
- 3 Prep the rest. Finely dice the red onion and red bell pepper; chop the dill.
- 4 Build the base. Whisk the mayonnaise, salt, and 3 tbsp reaper water into the apple mixture until smooth and evenly coated.
- 5 Fold together. Add the onion, bell pepper, and dill. Fold gently until everything is dressed.
- 6 Rest, then taste. Chill at least 30 minutes so the flavors meld and the heat settles into the background. Taste and adjust salt or lime before serving.

NO-HEAT VERSION

Skip step 1	Leave out the Carolina Reaper entirely — no boiling needed.
Swap the liquid	Replace the 3 tbsp reaper water with 3 tbsp cold water (keeps the same texture and dressing balance), or an extra squeeze of lime to taste.
Everything else	Identical — same dice, same dressing, same 30-minute chill.

CHEF'S NOTES

- Reaper water, not the pod. Boiling in plain water pulls a controlled amount of heat into the liquid (capsaicin is fat-soluble, so it extracts gently) — that's what gives the slow back-palate burn instead of a sharp front-tongue spike.
- Want more heat? Add reserved reaper water a teaspoon at a time after the rest (pushes heat without adding salt), or finely mince the boiled pod and stir in a little at a time. A whole reaper in a batch this size is a lot — build up gradually and taste as you go.
- Storage. Keeps 3–4 days sealed in the fridge; the apple softens over time, so it's best in the first day or two.
- Serving. Great on grilled or roasted chicken, pork, fish tacos, or as a dip with chips.